

Session 1: Considering the Authors' Intentions for Genesis

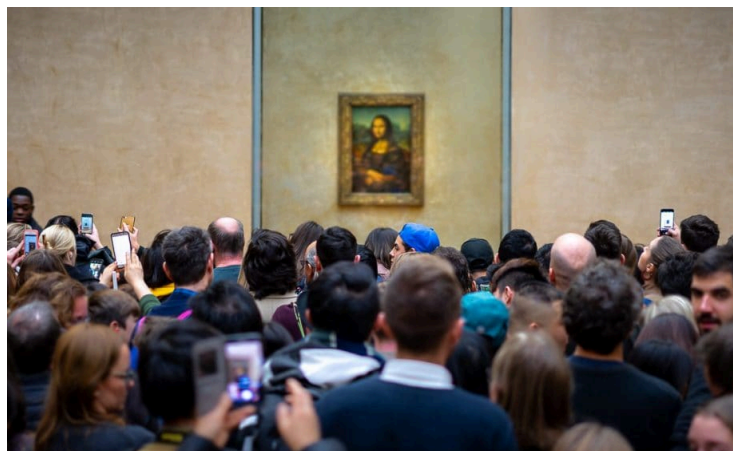
Key Takeaways

- It is helpful to be aware of our own assumptions and questions and pay attention to the intent of the biblical authors.
- These early chapters of Genesis form the introduction to the Hebrew Bible. The biblical authors crafted these stories to set the tone and expectations for what will come next.

The *Mona Lisa* Analogy

Every day, tens of thousands of people wait in line to see Leonardo da Vinci's famous painting *Mona Lisa*. In the five centuries since the masterpiece was created, the *Mona Lisa* has taken on a life of its own. People come from all over the world to see it—all with many different motivations and ideas of what the *Mona Lisa* means to them.

Much like the *Mona Lisa*, the early chapters of Genesis—the stories of Adam and Eve and the garden of Eden—have taken on a life of their own. While we all have important questions when we come to the biblical text, our priority is to intentionally focus on the questions the biblical authors were concerned about. We demonstrate love for our ancient Israelite neighbor by taking time to pause, recognize our questions, and set them to the side so we can really listen to what the biblical authors are trying to say.



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Reflection Question

Tim uses the example of people having all sorts of different questions when they visit the Mona Lisa. What does it mean to “step out of the Mona Lisa line” when talking about studying the Bible?